

Guide: Specification 44 vs NatHERS

What is NatHERS?

NatHERS (Nationwide House Energy Rating Scheme) is used in Australia to assess residential buildings' thermal performance, providing a star rating out of 10. Under the NCC 2022, new homes must typically achieve a 7-star minimum rating. The rating is calculated using accredited software and evaluates the heating and cooling needs of a home based on climate zone, materials, and design.

What is Specification 44?

Specification 44 is a pathway in the NCC 2022 that sets explicit heating and cooling load limits (measured in MJ/m²/year) to assess residential thermal performance. It is used as a Performance Solution for demonstrating compliance with energy efficiency provisions and offers a more precise and outcome-driven alternative to NatHERS star ratings.

Relationship Between Specification 44 and NatHERS

NatHERS and Specification 44 are both used to demonstrate compliance with the NCC energy efficiency requirements, but they represent different approaches: **NatHERS:** Provides a simplified, star-based assessment (Deemed-to-Satisfy pathway). **Specification 44:** Allows a Performance Solution by verifying that the building's heating and cooling loads are within specified limits. While NatHERS gives a general rating, Specification 44 focuses on actual thermal performance, which may be more appropriate for complex or non-standard designs.

Why Choose Specification 44 Over NatHERS?

There are several reasons to use Specification 44 instead of NatHERS: **Design Flexibility:** Greater freedom for non-standard or innovative designs. **Clear Performance Targets:** Easy-to-understand heating and cooling load limits. **Fallback Option:** Provides an alternative when a building can't achieve the 7-star NatHERS rating. **Performance-Focused:** Better aligns with Net Zero goals and carbon tracking. **Innovation-Friendly:** Supports new construction methods and materials not well-supported by NatHERS tools. **Avoid Full Certification:** May reduce certification time and cost for qualified projects.

When Not to Use Specification 44

This pathway is more complex and requires detailed modeling and documentation. For typical homes, NatHERS may be faster, more cost-effective, and more familiar to building certifiers.